COTS vs Build — Scoping & Pricing Engine

Why we build DealPad instead of buying a CPQ / PSA to do scope-to-fee · April 20, 2026

Question: Dynamics 365 (CRM), Workday (HCM/Fin), Intapp (Risk), Conga (letters), Power BI (analytics) are already decided as Buy + Integrate. The open question is the scope-to-fee engine: do we buy COTS or build DealPad? Per stakeholder direction, the comparison set below is true replacement alternatives — not the integrated stack.

1 · BUY TO ACCELERATE
CRM, HCM, contracts, financials, BI are commodity — already integrated (Dynamics, Workday, Intapp, Conga, Power BI).

2 · BUILD TO DIFFERENTIATE
Own the scope-to-fee engine: role hierarchy, complexity multipliers, scenario engine, AI calibrated on Armanino data.

3 · ISO 42001 AS A MOAT
An owned AI Management System per tenant is materially harder for any horizontal SaaS vendor to replicate.

COTS ALTERNATIVES THAT COULD REPLACE DEALPAD'S SCOPING & PRICING FUNCTION

PRODUCT	WHAT IT OFFERS FOR SCOPE & PRICING	WHY IT DOES NOT REPLACE DEALPAD FOR ARMANINO
Salesforce Revenue Cloud (CPQ + CLM)	CPQ rules engine, approval workflows, quote document generation, contract lifecycle; Einstein for forecasting / next-best-action.	CPQ is built around products and SKUs, not a 7-tier role hierarchy with complexity multipliers; service-hour assemblies and Standard/Premium/Value scenarios must be hand-built in CPQ rules / Apex; Einstein is generic forecasting, not Armanino effort/margin learning; introduces a second CRM stack alongside Dynamics; per-user licensing scales with every contributor.
Conga CPQ (separate from Composer doc engine)	Standalone CPQ with quote configuration, pricing rules, approval routing; pairs with Conga CLM.	Same product/SKU pricing model bias as Salesforce CPQ; cannot natively express role-loaded service-hour pricing or auto-generated scenarios; vendor AI surface is generic; would still need DealPad-style scoping logic on top.
Deltek Vantagepoint / Maconomy	ERP + PSA built for project-based professional-services firms: opportunity, project setup, role-based pricing, resourcing, billing, revenue recognition.	Closest single-vendor alternative for accounting-firm scope-to-fee, but the opportunity/scoping module is template-based, not a calibrated AI engine; ERP-class implementation; firm-specific scope catalog and complexity multipliers still require heavy customisation; no ISO 42001-aligned per-tenant AIMS evidence; high lock-in.
Kantata (formerly Kimble + Mavenlink)	PSA for services firms covering deal/opportunity, resource planning, project margin forecasting, time/expense, billing.	Opportunity & margin module covers part of DealPad's scenario surface but is generic across services verticals; no firm-specific role hierarchy or complexity multiplier IP; AI features are vendor-owned and shared across tenants; overlaps with Workday Financials, creating a second source of truth.
Certinia PSA (formerly FinancialForce)	Salesforce-native PSA: services CRM, project pricing, resource management, project accounting; tight Salesforce integration.	Inherits Salesforce CPQ's product-centric pricing model; firm-specific role-loaded pricing must be built on top; AI is Einstein/Salesforce-owned; assumes Salesforce as CRM (Armanino's CRM is Dynamics); platform lock-in to Salesforce ecosystem.
PROS Smart CPQ	AI-driven pricing optimisation, dynamic discounting, win-probability modelling on top of CPQ.	Calibrated for high-volume transactional B2B (manufacturing, distribution, travel), not low-volume professional-services engagements; opaque vendor AI; no native scenario / RBAC / approval workflow for service-hour scoping; would need wrapping in another product to be useful for Armanino.

DIMENSIONS — same options scored against a consistent rubric

OPTION	CAPABILITY FIT (SCOPE & PRICING)	TIME-TO-VALUE	CUSTOMIZATION COST	DATA RESIDENCY / GOVERNANCE	AI TRANSPARENCY	LOCK-IN RISK
Salesforce Revenue Cloud	Medium — product-centric CPQ	Medium	High (CPQ rules + Apex)	Vendor cloud	Vendor-owned (Einstein)	High
Conga CPQ	Medium — product-centric CPQ	Medium	High	Vendor cloud	Vendor-owned	Medium
Deltek Vantagepoint	Medium — PSA + ERP	Slow (ERP rollout)	High	Vendor cloud / on-prem	Vendor-owned	High
Kantata	Medium — generic PSA	Medium	Medium	Vendor cloud	Vendor-owned	Medium
Certinia PSA	Medium — Salesforce-native PSA	Medium	High (Salesforce platform)	Vendor cloud	Vendor-owned (Einstein)	High
PROS Smart CPQ	Low — wrong workload (transactional	Slow	High	Vendor cloud	Vendor-owned (opaque)	High
DealPad build	**Full — owns scoping & pricing + AI**	**Slower (build cycle)**	**Owned (low marginal)**	**Owned (firm tenant + audit)**	**Owned + ISO 42001-auditable**	**Low**

WHY DEALPAD BUILD WINS FOR SCOPING & PRICING

- **Scoped pricing assemblies:** 7-tier role hierarchy, complexity multipliers (0.8×–1.5×), scope catalog, automatic margin/fee recalc — not modelled by any product/SKU CPQ.
- **AI calibrated on Armanino data:** Five use cases (similarity, effort, margin, scenario, risk) grounded in DealPad's own historical data, not a generic vendor model.
- **Scenario engine + persona approval:** Std / Prem / Value with AI reasoning; six-persona RBAC, state machine, AI narrative on approvals, full audit trail.

ISO 42001 AS A GENUINE MOAT

- DealPad's AI sits inside Armanino's tenant, on Armanino's data, with Armanino's controls. COTS vendors' AIMS is the vendor's — scoped to their product and shared across tenants.
- 42001 needs per-tenant evidence (model purpose, dataset lineage, monitoring, override capture, improvement loops tied to firm risk appetite) — hard for a horizontal SaaS vendor to carry per firm.
- DealPad already has the primitives 42001 expects: persona RBAC, override-with-justification, AI narrative on approvals, activity log, source-tagged audit history. Formalising these turns engineering into a governance asset for regulated client work.

RECOMMENDATION — BUY / BUILD / REJECT

CAPABILITY AREA	DECISION	RATIONALE
Surrounding stack — CRM, HCM/Fin, Risk, Letters, BI	BUY + INTEGRATE	Dynamics 365, Workday, Intapp, Conga Composer, Power BI — already firm-standard and integrated; DealPad consumes/pushes via provider pattern.
Scope-to-fee engine, role pricing, complexity multipliers	BUILD (DealPad)	Encodes Armanino IP; no COTS in this set models service-hour assemblies this way.
Scenario generation & comparison (Std / Prem / Value)	BUILD (DealPad)	Differentiating UX and reasoning surface; absent from the COTS set.
AI use cases (similarity, effort, margin, scenario, risk)	BUILD (DealPad)	Trained on Armanino's own deal corpus; vendor AI is not effort/margin-tuned.
Multi-persona RBAC & approval workflow	BUILD (DealPad)	Firm-specific governance and audit shape; not a generic CRM workflow.
AI Management System (ISO/IEC 42001)	BUILD (DealPad)	Owned AIMS is the durable moat; tenant-specific evidence not provided by surveyed COTS.
End-to-end CPQ replacement (Salesforce / Conga CPQ)	REJECT	Product-centric pricing; service-hour assemblies still custom; introduces a second CRM stack alongside Dynamics.
Single-vendor PSA (Deltek / Kantata / Certinia)	REJECT	Template-based scoping, not a calibrated AI engine; firm catalog & multipliers still custom; no per-tenant ISO 42001 AIMS; high lock-in.
AI pricing optimisation (PROS Smart CPQ)	REJECT	Calibrated for transactional B2B, not low-volume professional services; no scoping/approval workflow.

All claims reference vendor public capability descriptions and DealPad integration docs (docs/integrations/api-overview.md; server/{dynamics,workday,intapp,conga}.ts). No pricing or proprietary statistics included.